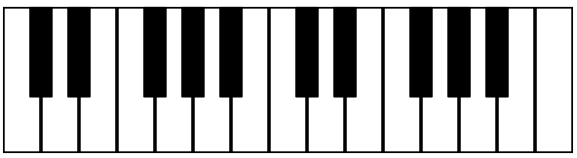
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 5 - Repertoire Reading



Middle C

Real piano music: two voices in one hand, chorales, chromatic notes, triplets, every key, the pedal and ornaments, with pieces by Bach, Beethoven, Schumann and Chopin.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

What is new in Volume 5

This is the last volume. The hand positions of Volumes 1-4 give way to reading as pianists do: by key, by chord shape and by pattern. Finger numbers now appear only where a passage needs a particular fingering. You will read two voices in one hand, four-part chorales, chromatic notes, triplets and four new time signatures, every major and minor key, the sustain pedal, clef changes and ornaments. Most of the pieces are real music: Bach chorales and inventions, Beethoven, Schubert, Schumann, Chopin and Satie. Start this book when you can read Volume 4 music: chords in both hands, ledger lines, syncopation, sixteenths and keys with three sharps or flats.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Name the key (the key signature and the last bass note) and the time signature. Look at the left hand's pattern: held chords, a waltz, a broken chord, a second voice? Find the highest and lowest notes, any accidentals, and any bar that repeats an earlier one. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, short examples, and reading tips. Parts A to C (sometimes D) are generated exercises that practise the new idea. The pieces come next: in this volume they are the heart of each unit, and most are real music by the great composers. A checkpoint ends the unit.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up with the scale and the I, IV and V chords of the day's key (2 minutes). Read 4-6 new exercises, one pass each (8 minutes). Then read one piece, or a page of one, and practise a passage from it (8 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 Two Voices in One Hand 4
A tune and a held voice in the same hand: stems up and stems down

Unit 2 Chorales
Four voices on two staves; chords on every degree of the scale, and first inversions

Unit 3 Chromatic Notes
Chromatic passing and neighbour notes, V7 of V, the melodic minor

Unit 4 Triplets and New Time Signatures
Eighth-note triplets; 3/8, 9/8, 12/8 and 2/2 (alla breve)

Unit 5 Four Sharps and Four Flats
E major and A-flat major; C-sharp minor (B-sharp) and F minor (E-natural)

Unit 6 Every Key
Five, six and seven sharps or flats; enharmonic keys (F-sharp = G-flat)

Unit 7 Pedal, Clefs and the Whole Keyboard
The sustain pedal; the left hand in the treble clef and the right hand in the bass clef

Unit 8 Counterpoint, Ornaments and Review
Sequences and imitation; trills, mordents, turns and grace notes; review

Unit 1

Two Voices in One Hand

New: A tune and a held voice in the same hand: stems up and stems down

Real piano music often asks one hand to play two things at once: a tune on top and a second, quieter voice underneath, or a bass note held while the hand moves above it. To show this, the music is written in two voices on the same staff. The upper voice has its stems up, the lower voice its stems down.
From this volume on there are no hand-position pictures. Read by key and by chord: before you play, name the key and look at the shapes the hands make.

What is new

Stems up, stems down

When a staff holds two voices, the upper voice's stems point up and the lower voice's stems point down, even where the notes are close together. Each voice has its own complete rhythm, so both must add up to a full bar.

A held note under a moving tune

A half or whole note with its stem down keeps sounding while the upper voice moves on. Hold it down with one finger (often the thumb in the right hand, or the little finger in the left) and play the tune with the others.

Shared notes
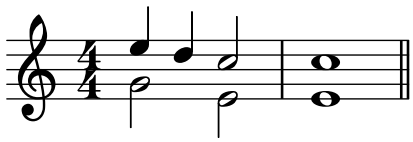
Where both voices sing the same note, it is printed once with two stems. Play it once.

Two voices in the left hand

The bass (stems down) holds while a tenor line (stems up) moves above it. The little finger holds the bass; the thumb and middle fingers play the tenor.
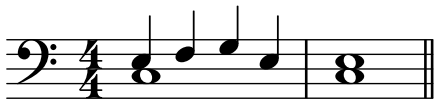
Two voices on one staff

Upper voice (stems up): E D C, then C. Lower voice (stems down): G held for two beats, then E. Count the voices separately: each adds up to a full bar.



A bass and a tenor in the left hand

The left hand holds C (stems down) while the tenor walks E F G E above it.



Reading tips

1. Before you play, find each voice's longest notes: those are the ones to hold.

2. Play the upper voice alone once in your head, then imagine the held notes underneath it.

3. Let the tune sing and keep the held voice quiet.

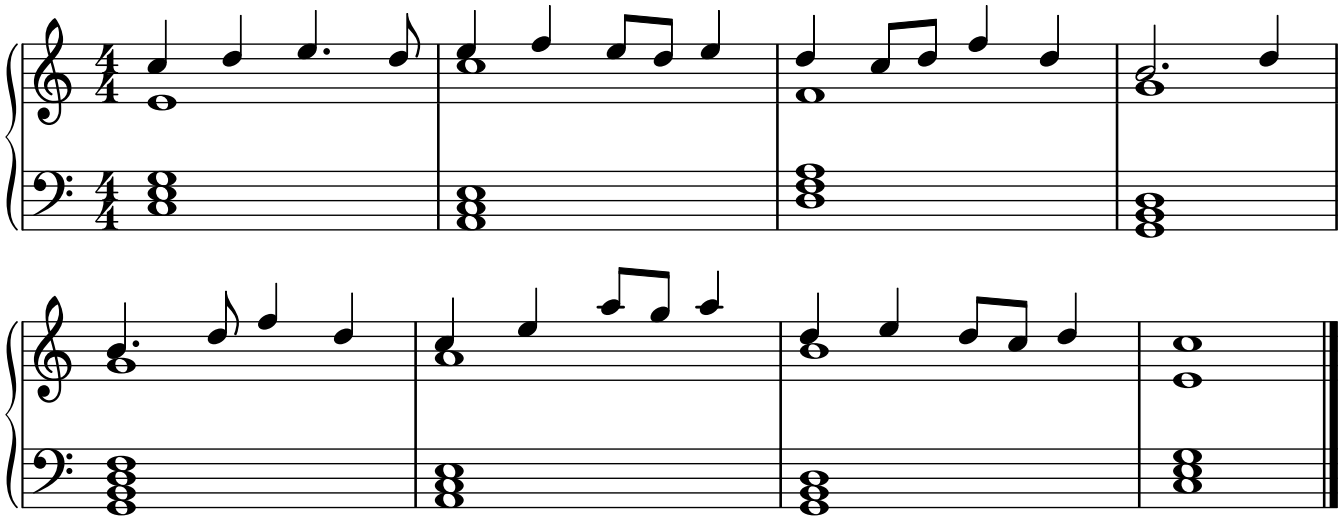
4. If a held note is hard to keep down, it is better to let it go a little early than to stop the beat.

Part A: A held voice under the tune

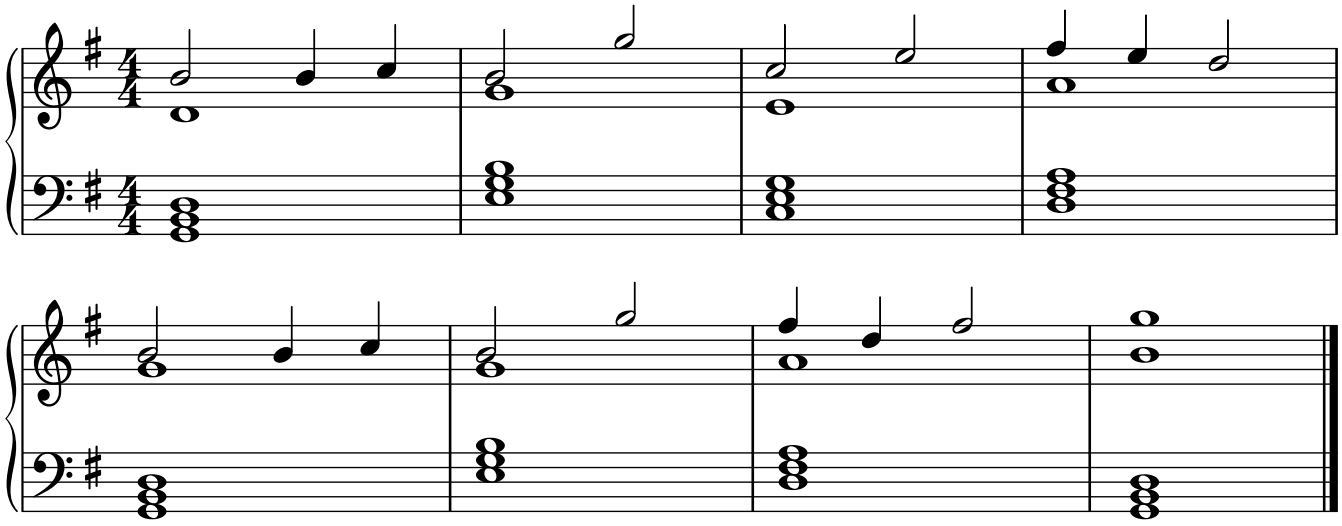
♩ = 66

C major and G major. The right hand holds the stems-down note for the whole bar while the tune moves above it. The left hand plays held chords.

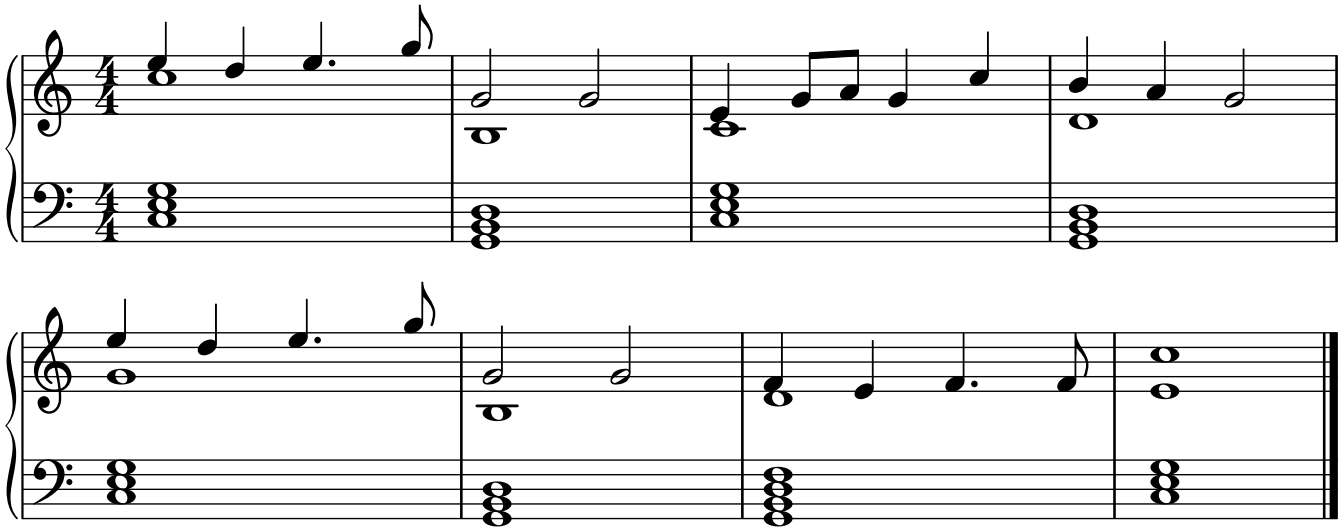
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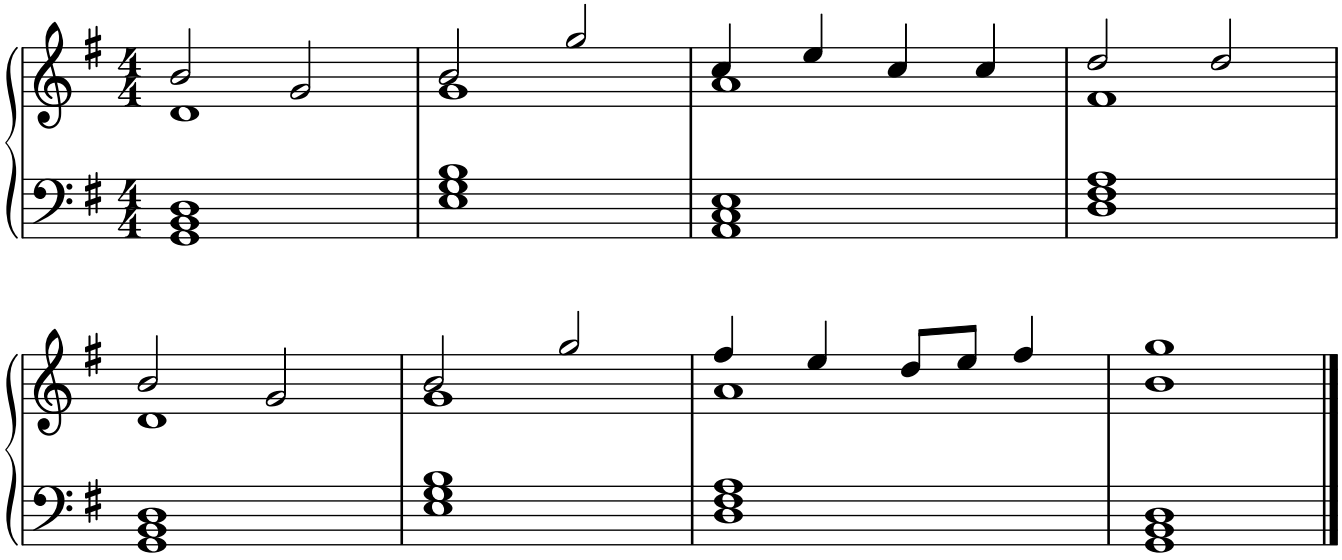
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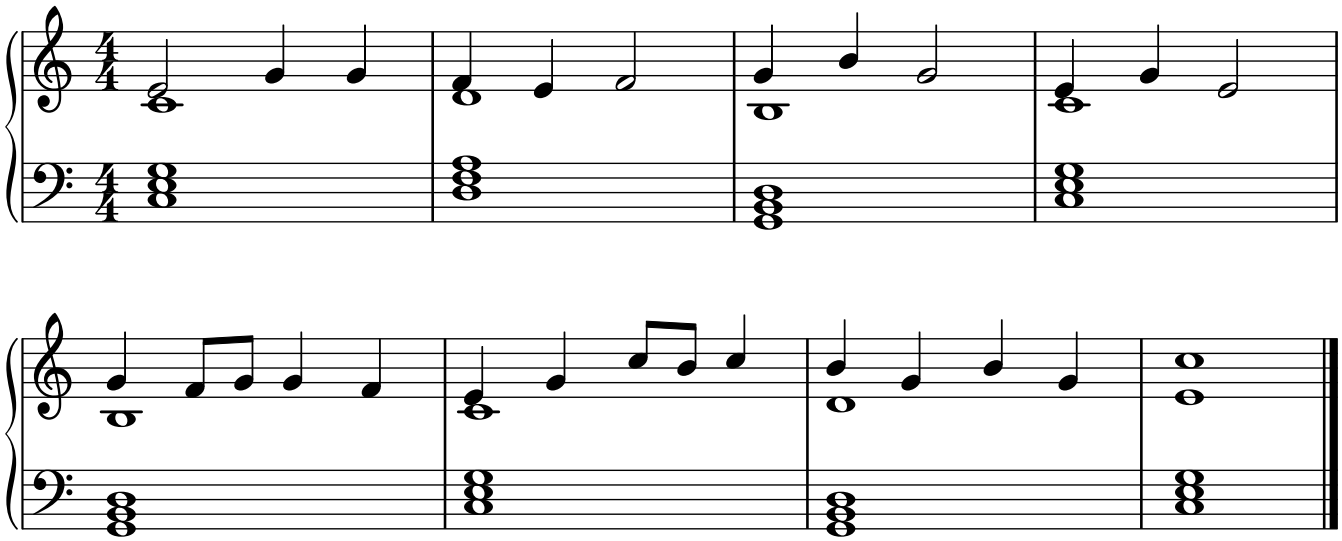
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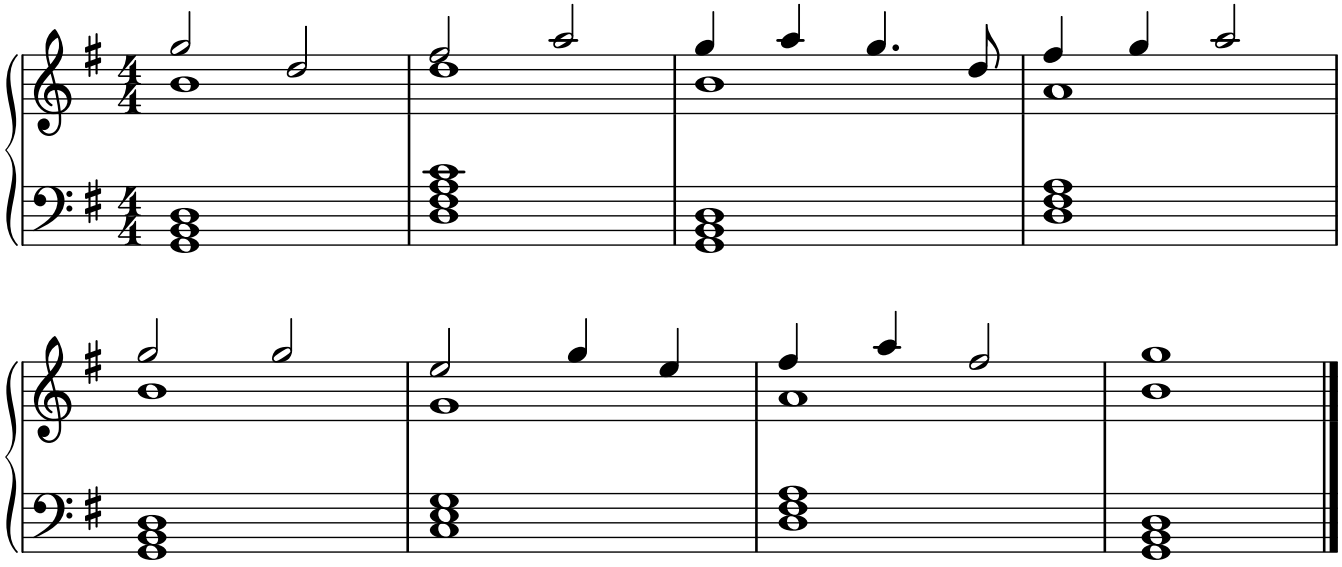
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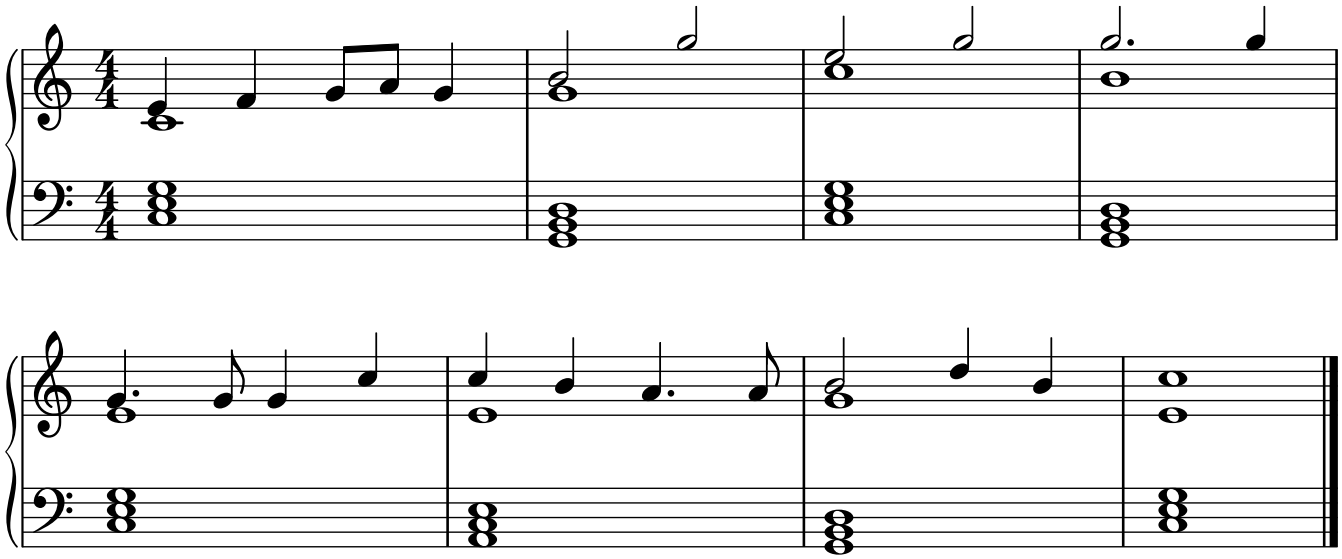


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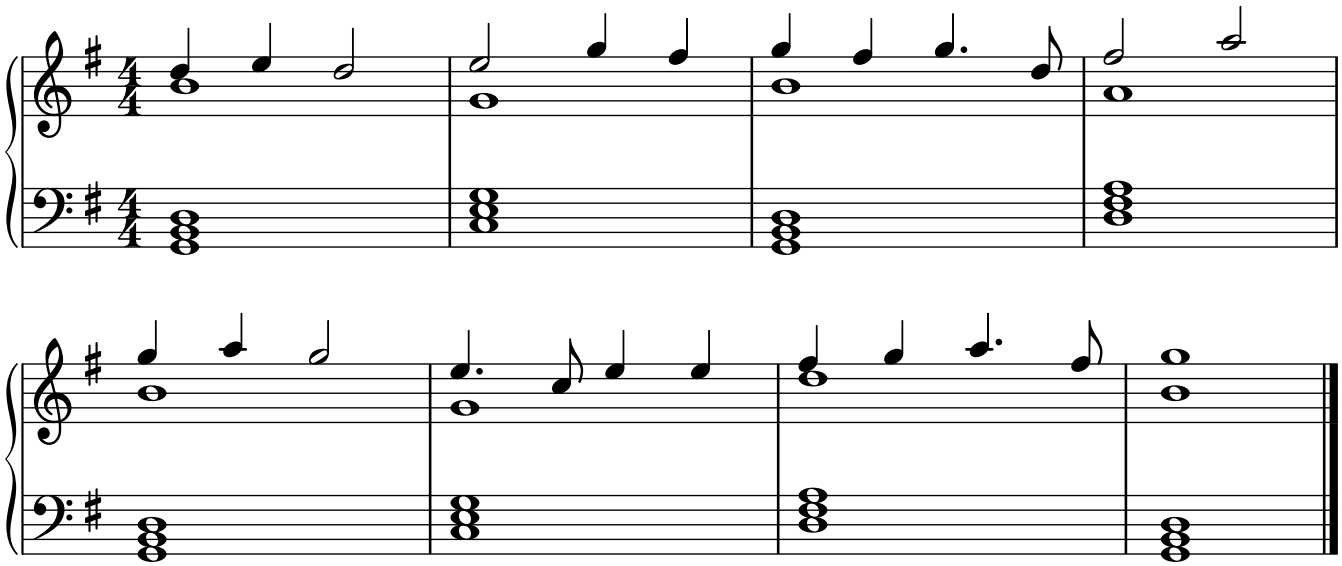
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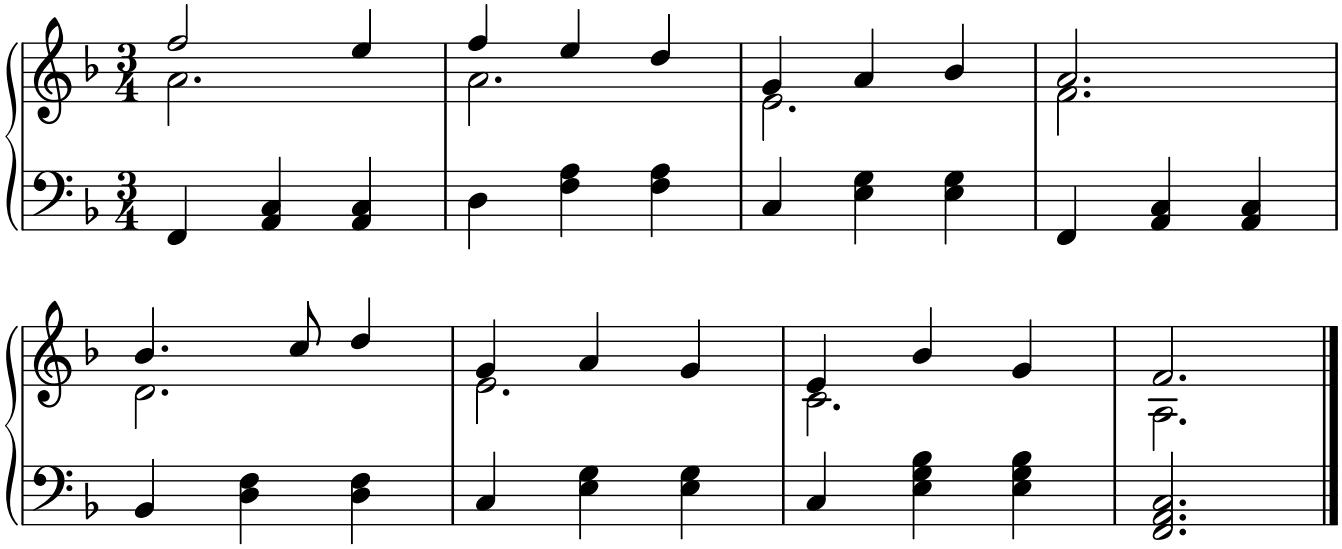


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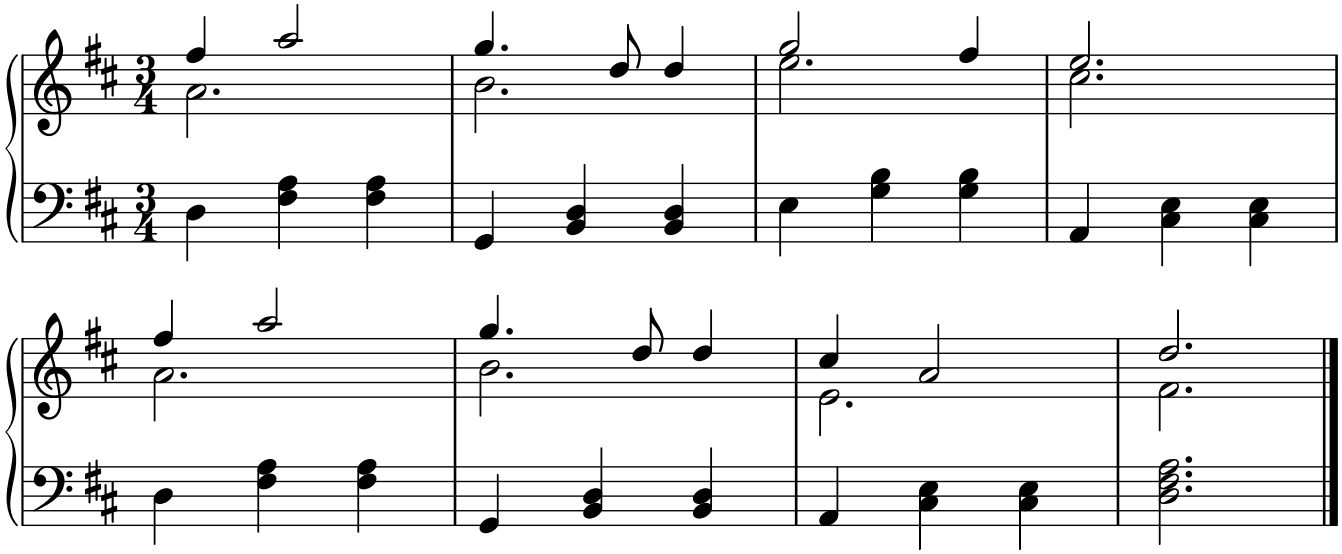


Part B: Held voices in 3/4 ♩ = 84

F major and D major in 3/4. The same two voices in the right hand, over a waltz bass.
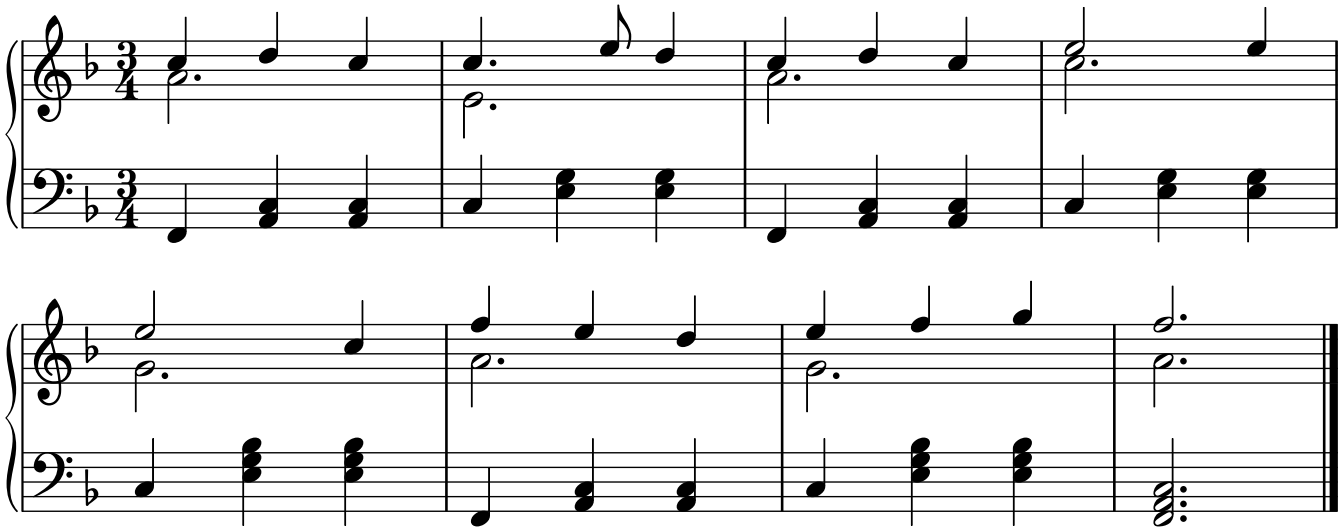
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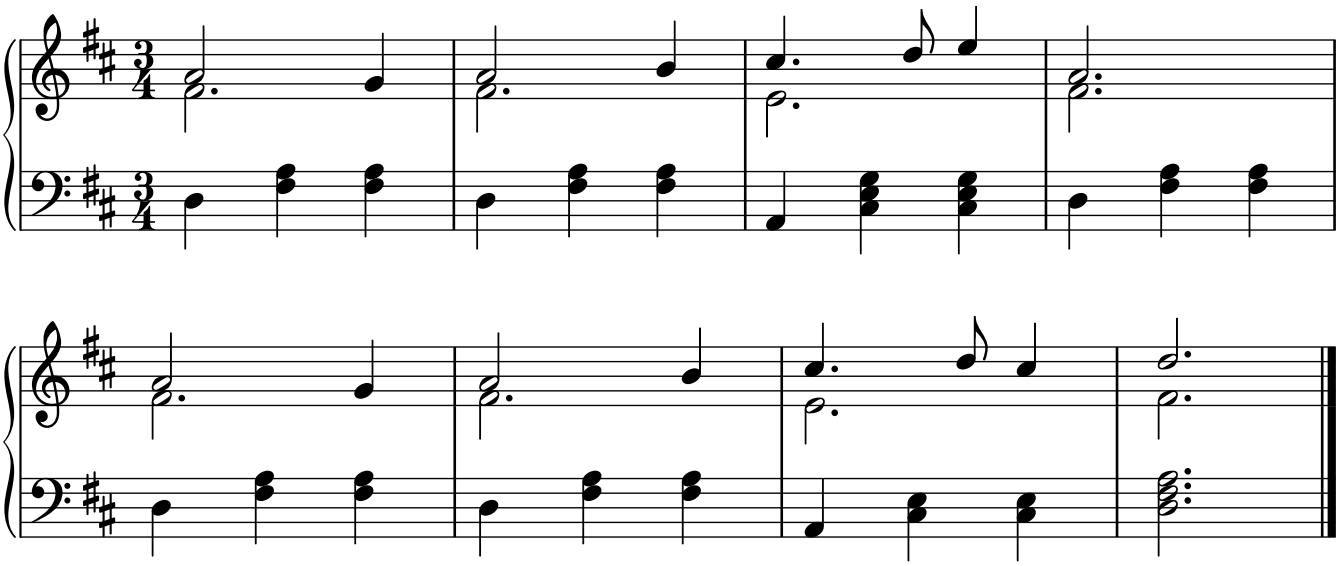


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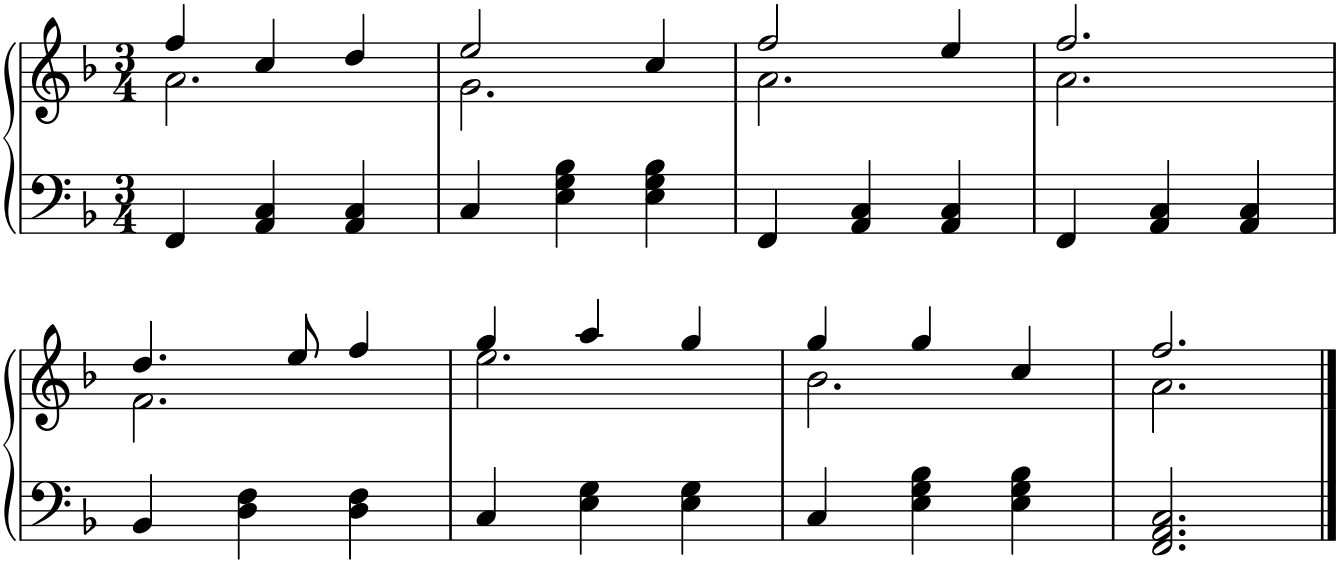


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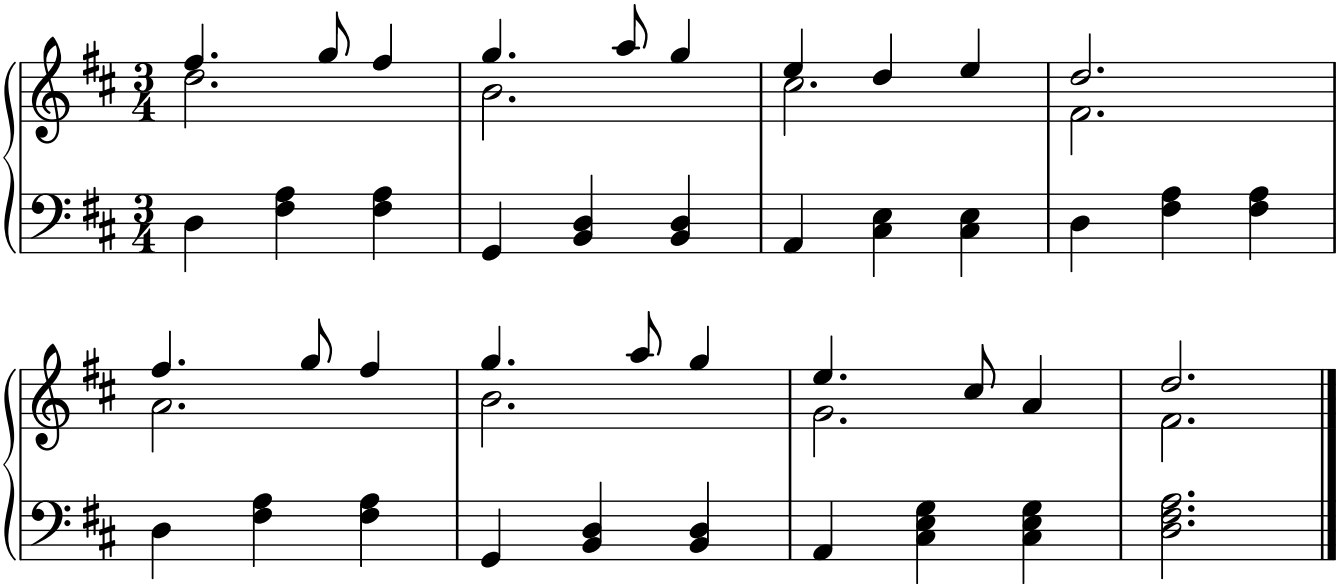


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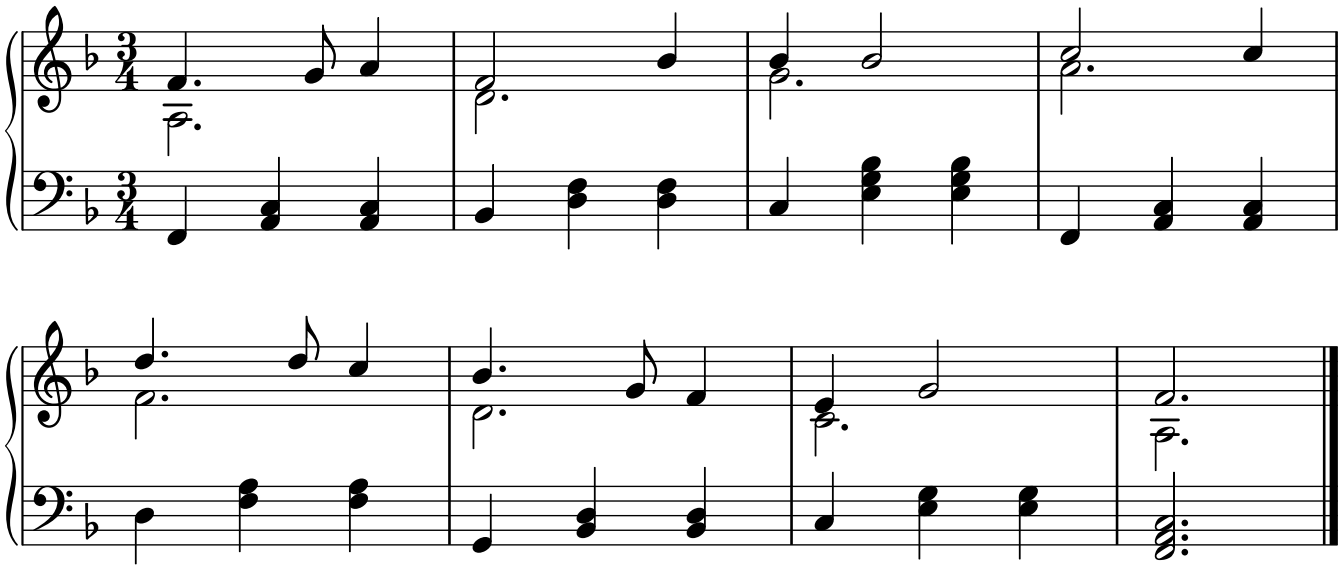


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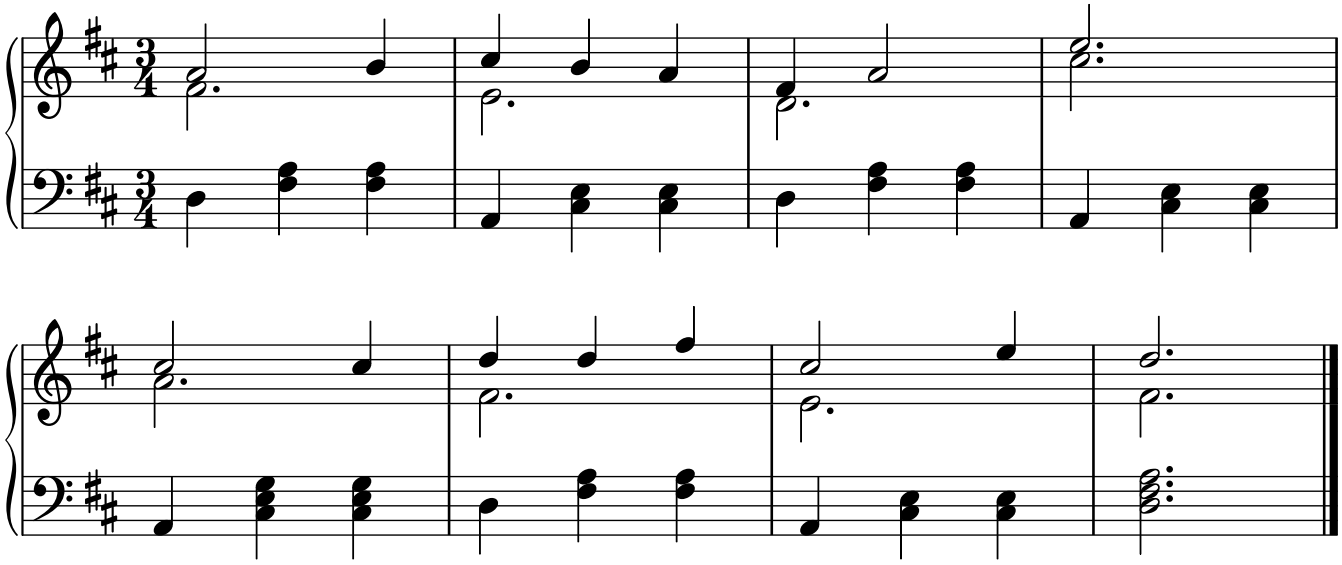


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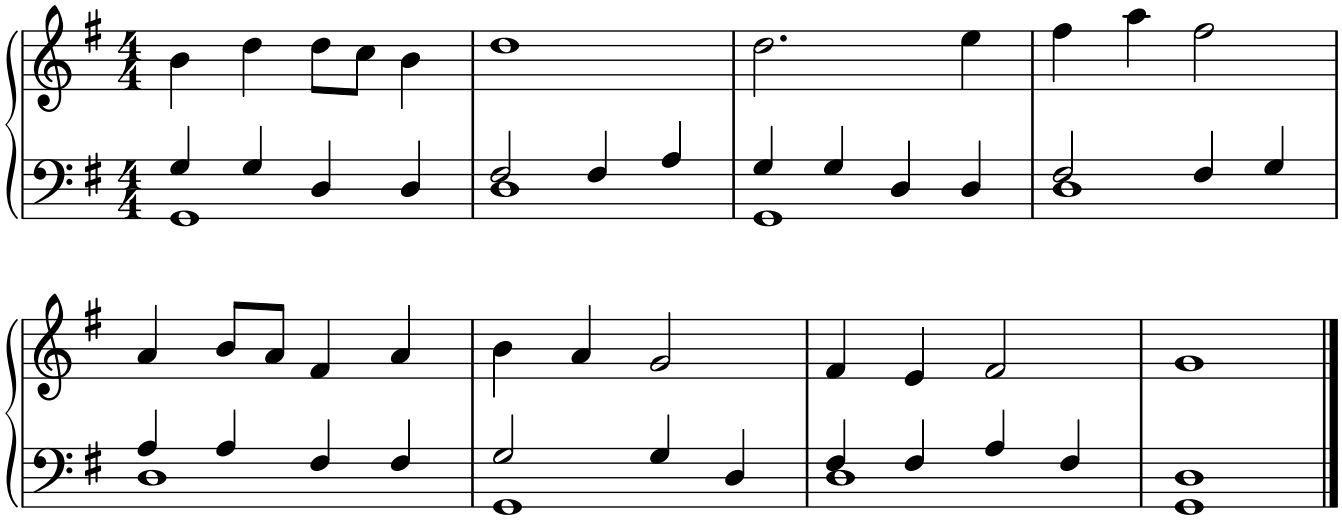
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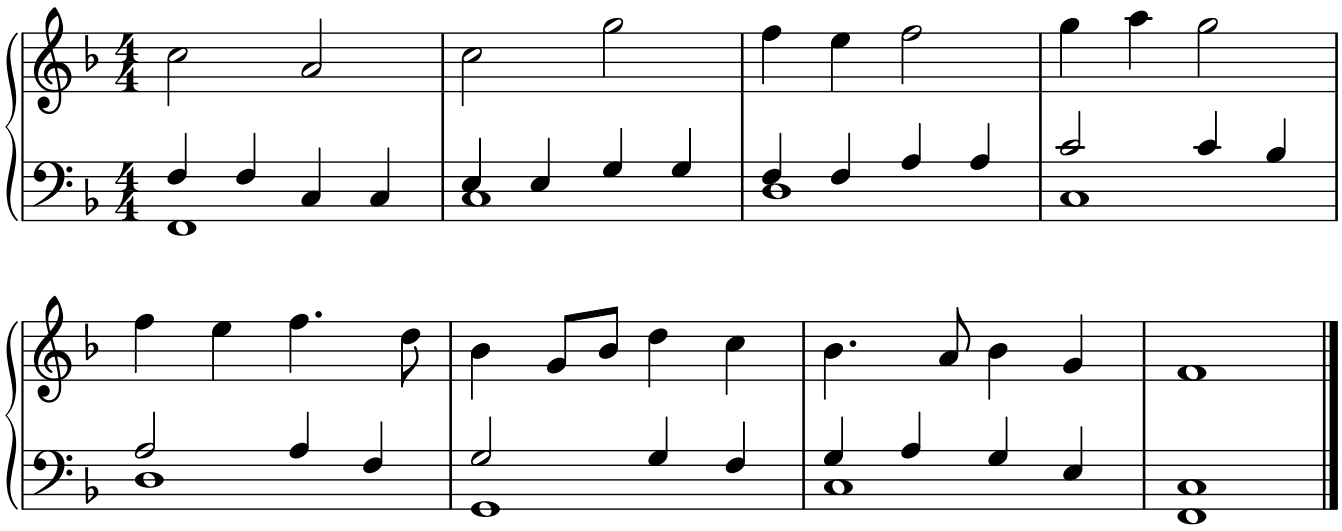


Part C: Two voices in the left hand ♩ = 60

G, F and B-flat major. The left hand holds the bass and plays a tenor line above it; the tune is in the right hand.
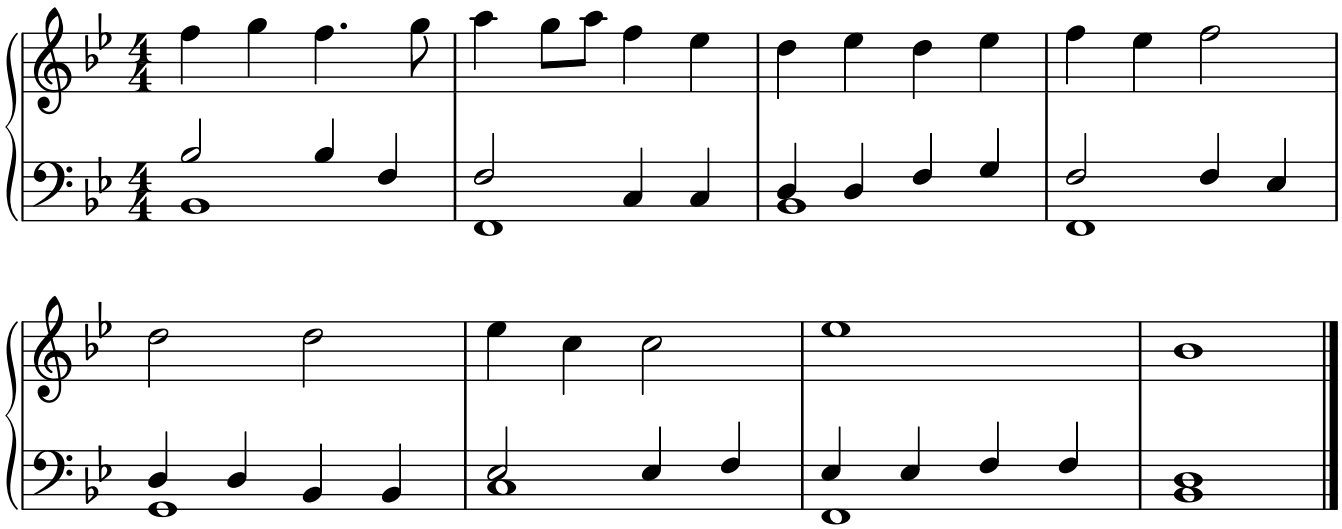
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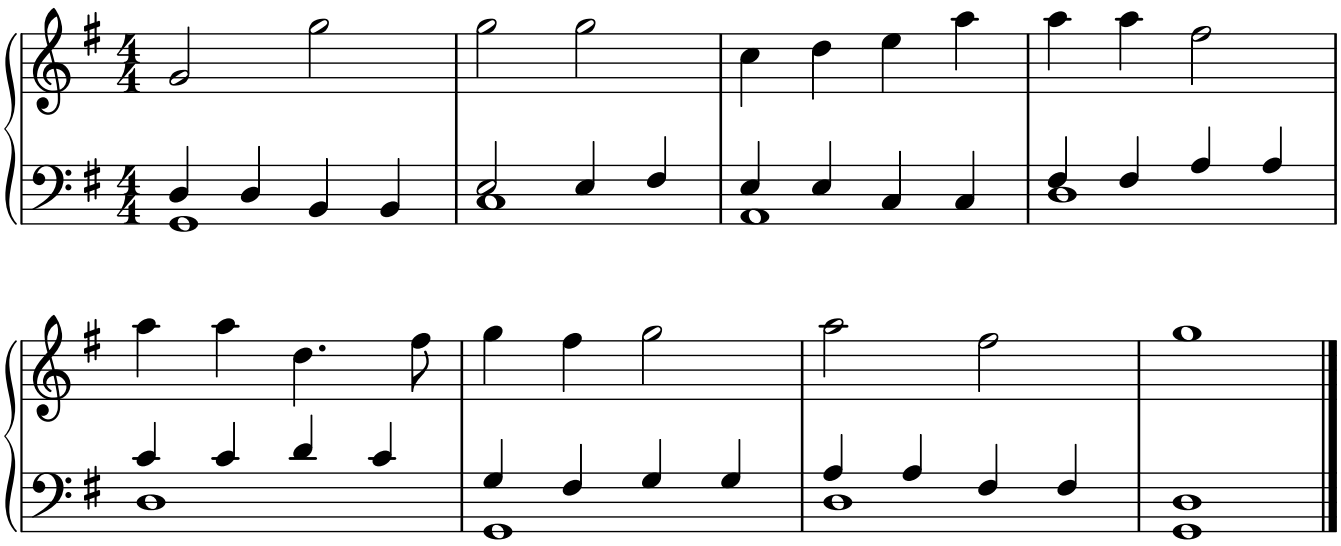
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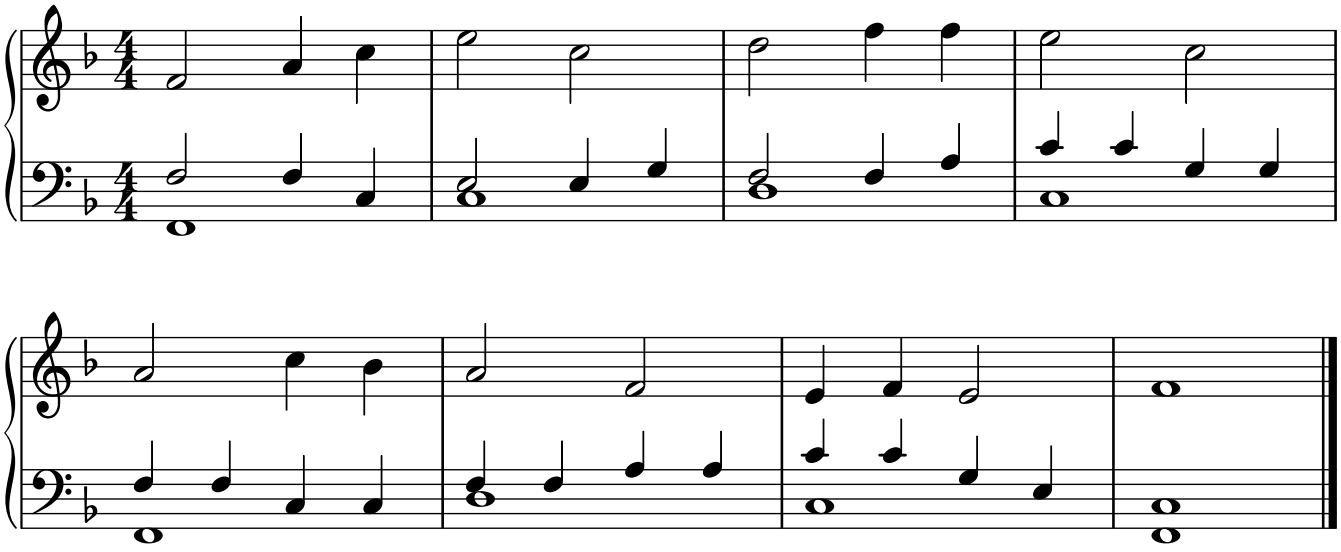
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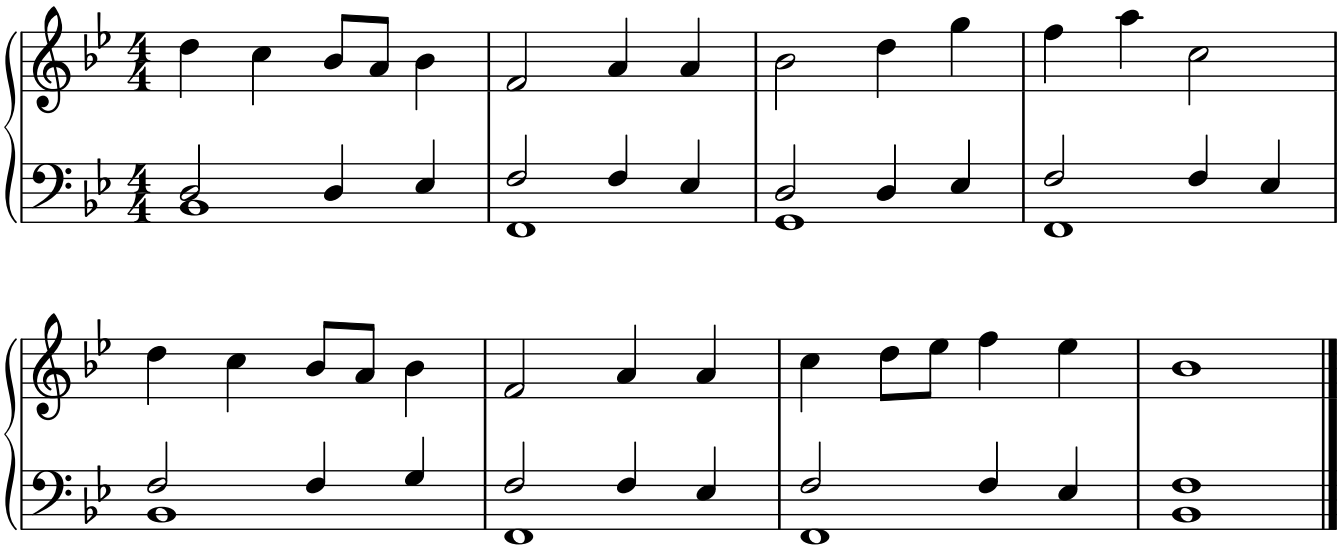


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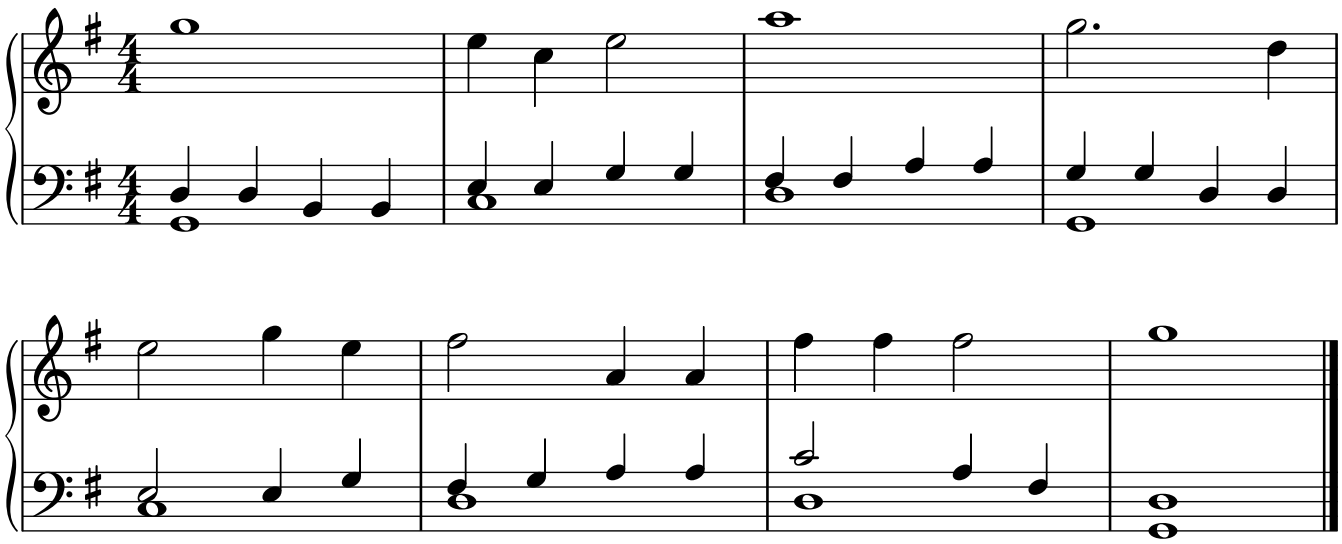
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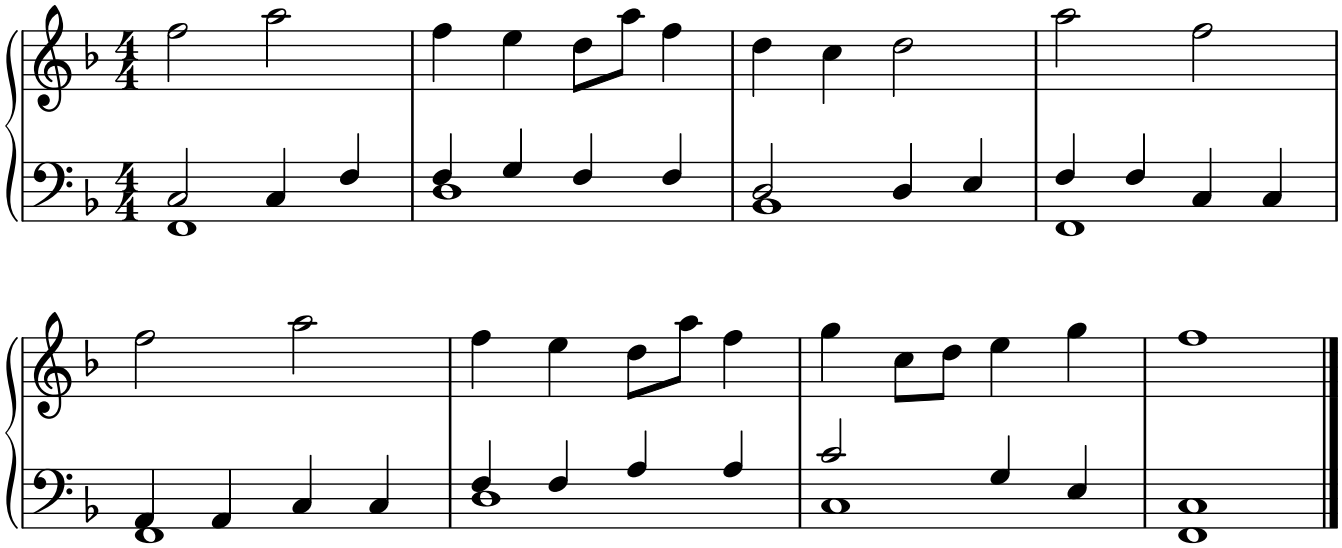


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☐ **1.23**



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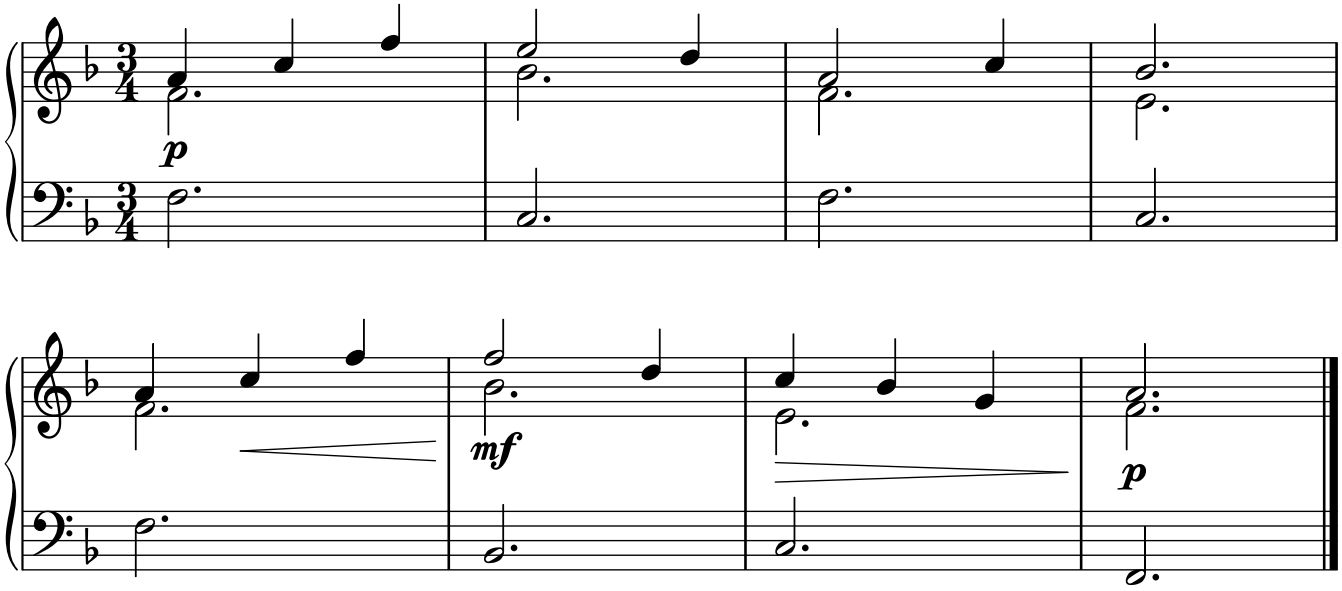


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Evening Bells ♩ = 80

Original
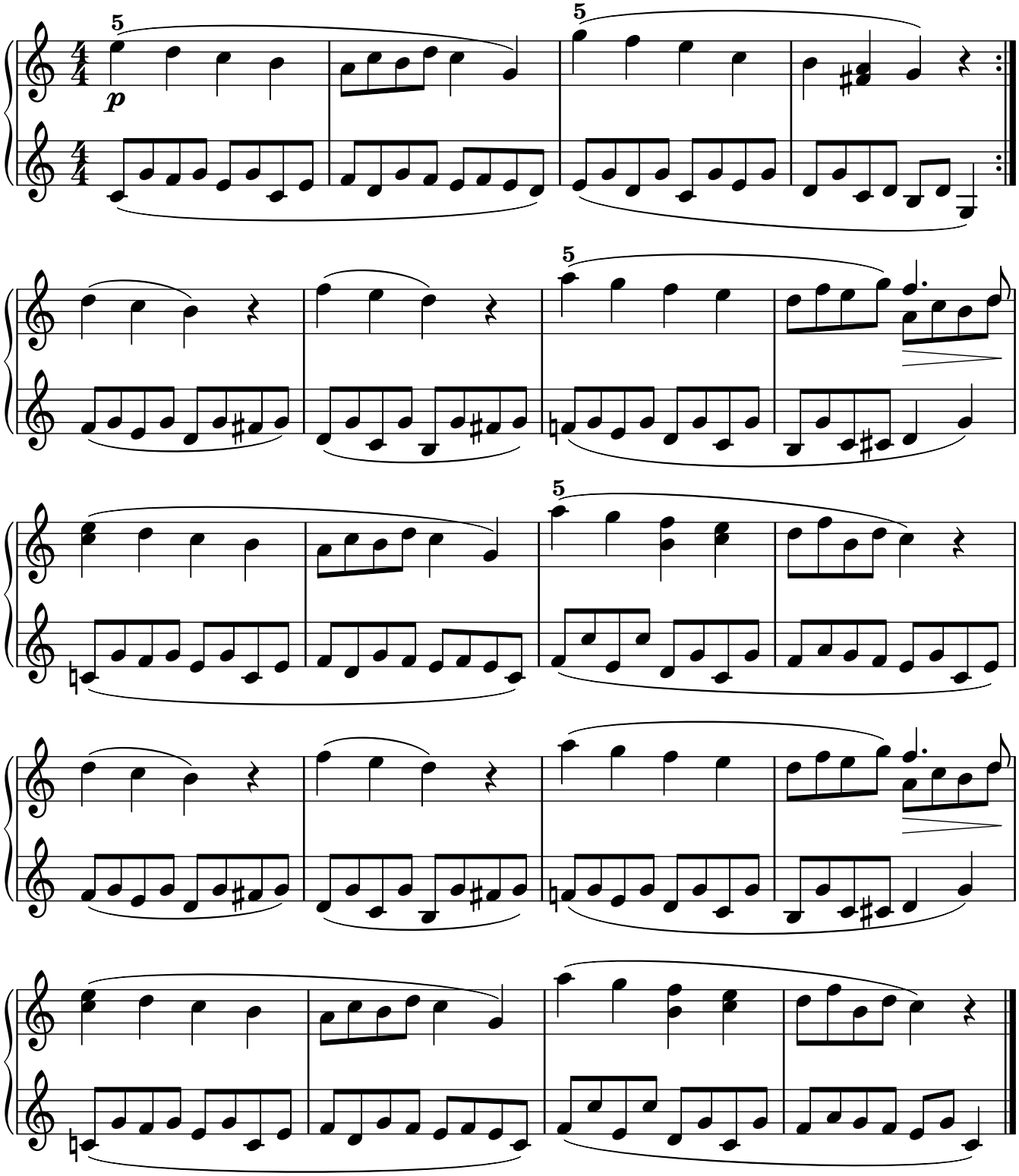
The right hand plays two voices: a tune with stems up, and a held note with stems down in every bar. Hold the lower note with the thumb (or finger 2 for the B-flats).



Melody ♩ = 72

Robert Schumann (1848), Album for the Young, Op. 68 No. 1 - complete
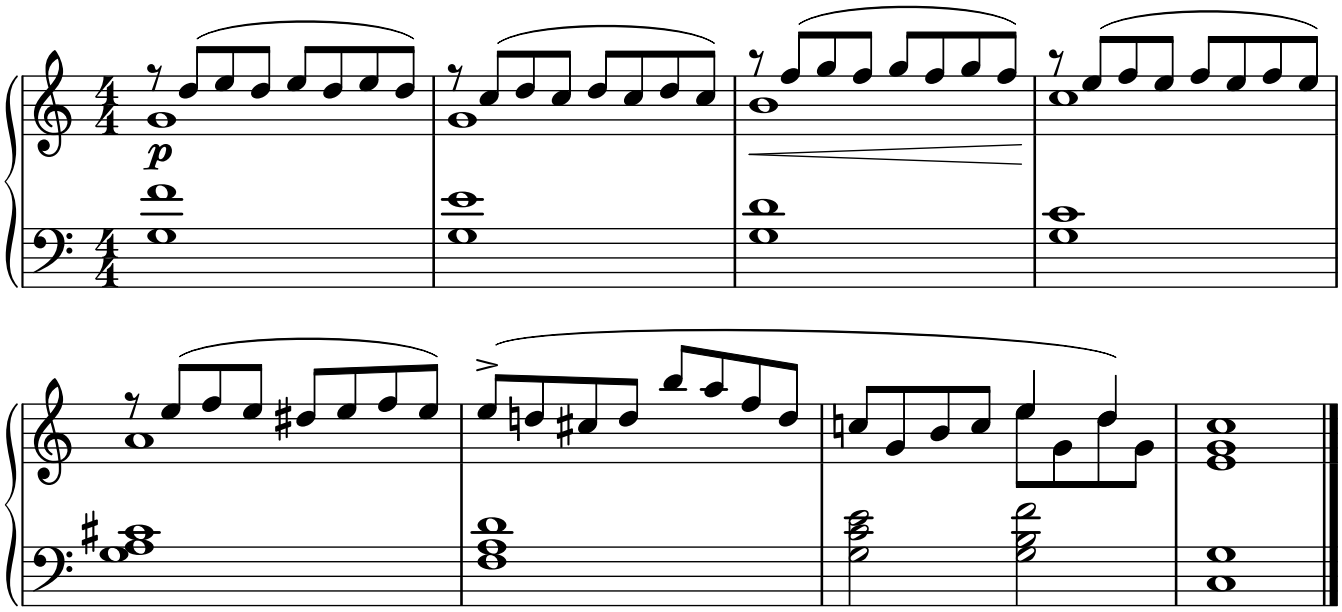
The first piece of Schumann's Album for the Young. The left hand plays above middle C, so it is written in the treble clef: read it like right-hand music. Its eighth notes are really two voices, a moving line and a repeated G above it. In bars 7 and 15 the right hand splits into two voices, and in bars 10 and 18 it jumps up from G to the high A. Play the repeat sign at bar 4: go back to the start once. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 647 by Philippe Hezaine (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Consolation ♩ = 72

Friedrich Burgmuller (1851), 25 Easy Studies, Op. 100 No. 13 - the introduction, with a closing chord added
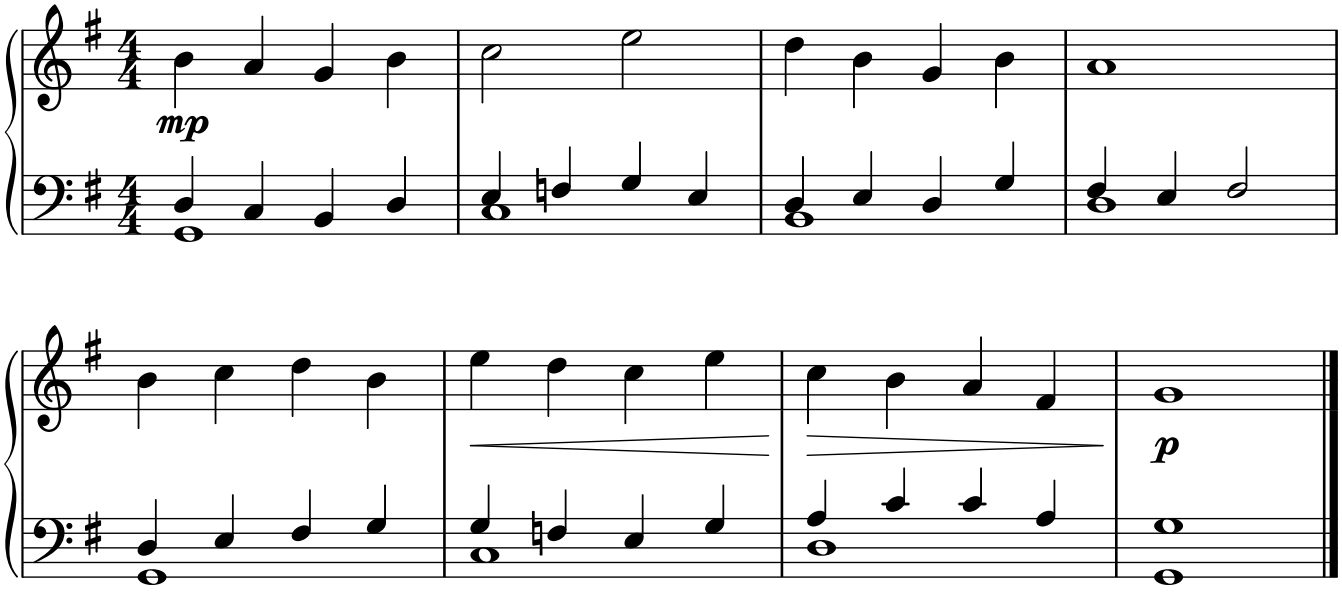
The right hand holds a long note (stems down) while its upper fingers rock between two notes. In bar 6 the two voices join into one line, and in bar 7 the tune (stems up) shares its notes with the eighth notes below it. The left hand reads above middle C with ledger lines. Source: Mutopia Project no. 224 (public domain).



Hymn with a Moving Tenor ♩ = 72

Original

Now the left hand has the two voices: the bass holds a whole note (stems down) while the tenor walks in quarter notes above it (stems up). Hold the bass with finger 5.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 2?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if every held note lasts its full length while the other voice keeps moving.
- Pass if you can play Evening Bells and the Hymn at sight, steadily, and Schumann's Melody after a week's practice.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 2.